

A UNIVERSAL FORCE

Egyptian magic

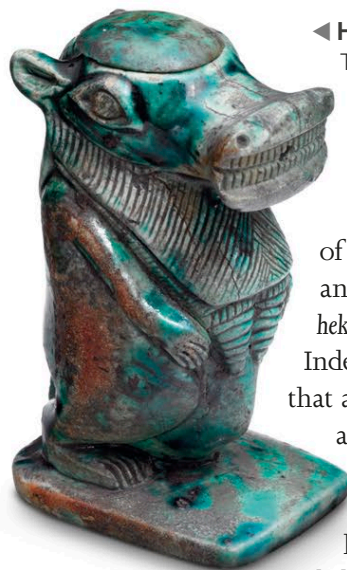
Heka (magic) was already at the heart of Egyptian beliefs by 4000 BCE. Creator deities such as Nu (the watery abyss) were said to have used *heka* to bring the world into existence from primordial chaos. In doing so, they subdued the forces of chaos, but the forces constantly sought to return and could only be stopped by *heka*. For the ancient Egyptians, it was not just the gods that handled magic. Lesser supernatural beings, pharaohs, and the dead were thought to possess an element of *heka*, which they could channel through the use of spells to deflect the attention of malevolent spirits.

Preserving cosmic harmony

The ancient Egyptians also believed in another form of magic power called *akhu*, which was malign and closely associated with beings of the underworld. To protect against *akhu* magical practitioners such as priests, scribes in the “Houses of Life”—which held the manuscript collections

▼ Wand of power

Curved wands of hippopotamus ivory carved with protective symbols were believed to protect children and pregnant women. This one has an inscription on the front reading “protection of day” and “protection of night.”



◀ Hippopotamus goddess

Taweret, depicted on this steatite jar, was believed to aid women during childbirth. The jar may have held a small papyrus with a magic spell to protect mother and child.

of Egyptian temples—*sunu* (doctors), and *sau* (amulet-makers) employed *heka* spells, rituals, and magical objects. Indeed, faith in *heka* was so widespread that ancient Egyptians used it in all aspects of life from matters of state to the delivery of oracles and more mundane village affairs, such as love matches, protection during childbirth, and curing minor illnesses.

As well as being an abstract force, there was a god called Heka who personified magic. Heka helped ensure the harmony of the cosmos and acted as a conduit through whom worshippers could seek divine favors. He had a female counterpart, Weret-hekau (Great of Magic), who was depicted in the form of a cobra. It is thought that the snake-headed staffs often used by ancient Egyptian magicians may have represented her.

Supernatural powers

Magic and religion enjoyed a close relationship in ancient Egypt. The same priests who performed ceremonies in the temples—channeling divine power via the pharaoh to ensure that the sun rose each morning and the Nile floods brought fertility to the land—chanted spells and blessed



“You put the shell of a crocodile’s egg inside the flame. It will be enchanted instantly.”

SPELL FROM THE LONDON-LEIDEN DEMOTIC PAPYRUS, 3RD CENTURY CE